

Machine Learning Complete Interview Preparation Guide

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Machine Learning — Complete Interview Preparation Guide

A detailed, structured reference covering ML fundamentals through advanced topics: theory, math intuition, code, pitfalls, and interview-style Q&A for each section.

Part 1: ML Fundamentals

1.1 What is Machine Learning?

Machine learning is the field of building systems that improve their performance on a task through experience (data), without being explicitly programmed with rules for every case. Instead of hand-coding logic, you provide examples, and the algorithm learns a function that maps inputs to outputs.

Formal definition (Tom Mitchell): A computer program is said to learn from experience E with respect to some task T and performance measure P , if its performance on T , as measured by P , improves with experience E .

Why ML instead of traditional programming?

Traditional programming: $\text{Rules} + \text{Data} \rightarrow \text{Output}$. Machine learning: $\text{Data} + \text{Output} \rightarrow \text{Rules (model)}$. ML is used when: - The rules are too complex to hand-code (e.g. image recognition). - The rules change over time (e.g. spam patterns, fraud tactics). - You have lots of data but no clear formula (e.g. recommendation systems).

Categories of ML

1. **Supervised Learning** — learn from labeled data (input-output pairs).
2. **Unsupervised Learning** — find structure in unlabeled data.
3. **Semi-supervised Learning** — a mix: small labeled set + large unlabeled set.
4. **Reinforcement Learning** — learn via trial and error, guided by rewards.

5. **Self-supervised Learning** — generate labels from the data itself (common in modern deep learning, e.g. predicting masked words).

The Machine Learning Pipeline

1. **Problem framing** — define the task (classification, regression, etc.) and success metric.
2. **Data collection** — gather relevant, representative data.
3. **Data cleaning & preprocessing** — handle missing values, outliers, encoding.
4. **Feature engineering** — create/select the most useful input variables.
5. **Model selection** — choose an appropriate algorithm.
6. **Training** — fit the model to training data.
7. **Evaluation** — measure performance on held-out data.
8. **Tuning** — adjust hyperparameters, iterate.
9. **Deployment** — serve the model in production.
10. **Monitoring** — track performance over time, detect drift, retrain as needed.

Common Interview Q&A

Q: What's the difference between AI, ML, and Deep Learning? AI is the broad field of building systems that mimic intelligent behavior. ML is a subset of AI where systems learn patterns from data rather than following hard-coded rules. Deep Learning is a subset of ML using multi-layered neural networks, particularly effective for unstructured data like images, audio, and text.

Q: Give an example of a real-world ML system and what type of learning it uses. A spam filter is supervised learning (trained on emails labeled spam/not-spam). A customer segmentation tool is unsupervised learning (clustering customers without predefined labels). A game-playing AI (e.g. AlphaGo) is reinforcement learning (learns via reward signals from winning/losing).

1.2 Types of Data

- **Structured data**: tabular, rows and columns (e.g. spreadsheets, SQL tables).
- **Unstructured data**: text, images, audio, video — no fixed schema.
- **Semi-structured data**: JSON, XML — has some organizational structure but not rigid.

Feature types

- **Numerical (continuous)**: age, income, temperature.
- **Numerical (discrete)**: number of children, count of items.
- **Categorical (nominal)**: no inherent order — color, city.
- **Categorical (ordinal)**: has order — education level, rating (low/medium/high).
- **Binary**: yes/no, true/false.
- **Time-series**: sequential, time-dependent data.

Interview Q&A

Q: How do you handle categorical variables before feeding them into an ML model?

Depends on the type. For nominal categories with no order, use **one-hot encoding** (creates a binary column per category) — appropriate when the number of categories is small. For ordinal categories, use **label/ordinal encoding**, preserving the rank order. For high-cardinality categorical features (many unique values, e.g. zip codes), consider **target encoding** or **embedding layers** (in deep learning) instead of one-hot, to avoid an explosion in dimensionality.

Part 2: Supervised vs Unsupervised Learning

2.1 Supervised Learning

The model learns a mapping $f(x) \rightarrow y$ from labeled training examples, where y is known during training. The goal is to generalize this mapping to predict y for new, unseen x .

Two main types: - **Regression:** predicting a continuous value (e.g. house price, temperature). - **Classification:** predicting a discrete category (e.g. spam/not spam, disease/no disease).

Common algorithms: Linear Regression, Logistic Regression, Decision Trees, Random Forest, Gradient Boosting (XGBoost/LightGBM), Support Vector Machines, K-Nearest Neighbors, Neural Networks.

Loss functions: - Regression: Mean Squared Error (MSE), Mean Absolute Error (MAE), Huber Loss. - Classification: Cross-Entropy Loss (Log Loss), Hinge Loss (SVM).

2.2 Unsupervised Learning

The model finds patterns or structure in data **without** labeled outputs. There's no "correct answer" to check against during training — success is judged by how well the discovered structure aligns with the data's natural organization (or downstream task usefulness).

Main types: - **Clustering:** grouping similar data points (e.g. K-Means, Hierarchical Clustering, DBSCAN). - **Dimensionality Reduction:** compressing features while preserving important structure (e.g. PCA, t-SNE, Autoencoders). - **Association Rule Learning:** finding relationships between variables (e.g. market basket analysis — "customers who buy X also buy Y"). - **Anomaly Detection:** identifying rare/unusual data points (e.g. fraud detection, defect detection).

2.3 Semi-Supervised & Self-Supervised Learning

Semi-supervised: uses a small amount of labeled data plus a large amount of unlabeled data — useful when labeling is expensive (e.g. medical imaging) but raw data is abundant.

Self-supervised: the model creates its own labels from the input data's structure — e.g. predicting a masked word in a sentence (BERT), or predicting the next frame in a video. This has become central to modern large language models and vision transformers, since it lets models pretrain on massive unlabeled datasets.

Interview Q&A

Q: How would you decide whether a problem is supervised or unsupervised? Ask: do I have labeled outcomes for my training data, and is my goal to predict a specific target for new data? If yes → supervised. If I only have raw data and want to discover hidden structure, groupings, or reduce dimensionality without a specific target variable → unsupervised. In practice, many real projects start unsupervised (exploring, clustering, understanding data) before moving to a supervised model once a clear prediction target and labeled data are established.

Q: Can you convert an unsupervised problem into a supervised one? Yes — a common technique is using unsupervised methods (like clustering) to generate pseudo-labels, then training a supervised model on those labels. This is also the essence of self-supervised learning, where labels are algorithmically derived from the data itself rather than manually annotated.

Part 3: Regression

3.1 Linear Regression

Linear regression models the relationship between a dependent variable y and one or more independent variables x as a linear function:

$$y = w_1x_1 + w_2x_2 + \dots + w_nx_n + b$$

Objective: minimize the sum of squared residuals (differences between predicted and actual values) — this is called **Ordinary Least Squares (OLS)**.

$$\text{Loss (MSE)} = (1/n) * \sum (y_i - y_{\text{pred}_i})^2$$

Assumptions of Linear Regression

1. **Linearity** — the relationship between X and y is linear.
2. **Independence** — observations are independent of each other.
3. **Homoscedasticity** — constant variance of residuals across all levels of X .
4. **Normality of residuals** — residuals are approximately normally distributed.
5. **No multicollinearity** — independent variables aren't highly correlated with each other.

Solving Linear Regression

Closed-form (Normal Equation):

$$w = (X^T X)^{-1} X^T y$$

Exact solution, but computationally expensive for large feature counts (matrix inversion is $O(n^3)$).

Gradient Descent: iteratively update weights in the direction that reduces loss:

```
def linear_regression_gd(X, y, lr=0.01, epochs=1000):
    n, m = len(X), len(X[0])
    w = [0.0]*m
    b = 0.0
    for _ in range(epochs):
        y_pred = [sum(w[j]*X[i][j] for j in range(m)) + b for i in range(n)]
        dw = [(-2/n) * sum((y[i]-y_pred[i])*X[i][j] for i in range(n)) for j in range(m)]
        db = (-2/n) * sum(y[i]-y_pred[i] for i in range(n))
        w = [w[j] - lr*dw[j] for j in range(m)]
        b -= lr*db
    return w, b
```

Preferred when the feature count is very large, or when using online/streaming learning.

Regularized Linear Regression

- **Ridge Regression (L2)**: adds $\lambda \sum w^2$ to the loss — shrinks coefficients smoothly, handles multicollinearity well.
- **Lasso Regression (L1)**: adds $\lambda \sum |w|$ — drives some coefficients to exactly zero, performing automatic feature selection.
- **Elastic Net**: combines both L1 and L2 penalties — useful when you want sparsity but also stability with correlated features.

Interview Q&A

Q: What happens if features are highly correlated (multicollinearity)? Coefficient estimates become unstable and have high variance — small changes in the data can cause large swings in the estimated weights, and it becomes hard to interpret individual feature importance since correlated features “share” the explanatory power unpredictably. Ridge regression is a common remedy since it shrinks correlated coefficients together rather than arbitrarily favoring one.

Q: Why use MSE instead of MAE as the default loss for linear regression? MSE is differentiable everywhere (smooth), which makes gradient-based optimization straightforward, and it penalizes larger errors more heavily (quadratically), which is often desirable. MAE is more robust to outliers (penalizes linearly) but is non-differentiable at zero, complicating some optimization methods — though this is manageable with subgradients.

3.2 Polynomial Regression

Extends linear regression by adding polynomial terms (x^2 , x^3 , etc.) as additional features, allowing the model to fit non-linear relationships while still being “linear” in terms of the coefficients being estimated.

```
# Manually create polynomial features
def polynomial_features(x, degree=3):
    return [xi**d for d in range(1, degree+1)] for xi in x]
```

Risk: higher-degree polynomials can overfit badly, oscillating wildly between data points (especially near the edges of the data range — Runge’s phenomenon). Always validate with held-out data when choosing polynomial degree.

3.3 Evaluating Regression Models

Metric	Formula (conceptual)	Notes
MAE	Average of actual - predicted	Robust to outliers, same units as target
MSE	Average of (actual - predicted) ²	Penalizes large errors heavily
RMSE	$\sqrt{\text{MSE}}$	Same units as target, still penalizes large errors
R ²	1 - (SS_residual / SS_total)	Proportion of variance explained; 1 = perfect fit

Adjusted R ²	Penalizes R ² for adding useless features	Better for comparing models with different feature counts
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Interview Q&A

Q: Why might R² increase when you add a useless feature to the model, and how do you correct for it? R² never decreases when adding features, even irrelevant ones, because the model has more freedom to fit noise in the training data. **Adjusted R²** corrects this by penalizing the addition of features that don't meaningfully improve the model, factoring in the number of predictors relative to sample size — it can decrease if a new feature doesn't pull its weight.

Part 4: Classification

4.1 Logistic Regression

Despite the name, logistic regression is a classification algorithm. It models the probability that an input belongs to a class using the **sigmoid function**:

$$p = 1 / (1 + e^{(-z)}), \text{ where } z = w_1x_1 + \dots + w_nx_n + b$$

Output p is a probability between 0 and 1; a threshold (commonly 0.5) converts it into a class prediction.

Loss function — Binary Cross-Entropy:

$$\text{Loss} = -(1/n) * \sum [y_i * \log(p_i) + (1-y_i) * \log(1-p_i)]$$

Multi-class extension: Softmax regression (multinomial logistic regression) generalizes this to multiple classes using the softmax function, which outputs a probability distribution across all classes.

```
import math

def sigmoid(z):
    return 1 / (1 + math.exp(-z))

def predict_proba(x, w, b):
    z = sum(w[i]*x[i] for i in range(len(x))) + b
    return sigmoid(z)
```

Interview Q&A

Q: Why can't you use MSE as the loss function for logistic regression? Combining MSE with a sigmoid output produces a non-convex loss surface, so gradient descent can get stuck in local minima. Cross-entropy loss, paired with sigmoid, produces a convex loss function for logistic regression, guaranteeing gradient descent converges to the global minimum.

Q: How do you interpret logistic regression coefficients? Each coefficient represents the change in the **log-odds** of the outcome for a one-unit increase in that feature, holding others constant. Exponentiating a coefficient (e^w) gives the **odds ratio** — how much the odds of the

positive class multiply for a one-unit increase in that feature.

4.2 K-Nearest Neighbors (KNN)

A non-parametric, instance-based algorithm: to classify a new point, find the k closest training points (by some distance metric, usually Euclidean) and take a majority vote of their labels.

```
import math
from collections import Counter

def euclidean(a, b):
    return math.sqrt(sum((a[i]-b[i])**2 for i in range(len(a))))

def knn_predict(X_train, y_train, x_query, k=1):
    distances = sorted(
        [(euclidean(x_query, X_train[i]), y_train[i]) for i in range(len(X_train))],
        key=lambda pair: pair[0]
    )
    k_nearest = [label for _, label in distances[:k]]
    return Counter(k_nearest).most_common(1)[0][0]
```

Choosing k : small $k \rightarrow$ low bias, high variance (sensitive to noise). Large $k \rightarrow$ high bias, low variance (smoother decision boundary, may underfit). Odd k values are preferred in binary classification to avoid ties.

Downsides: slow at prediction time (must compute distance to all training points — $O(n)$ per query, unless using KD-trees/Ball trees for speedup), sensitive to feature scaling (always normalize/standardize features first), and suffers from the curse of dimensionality (distances become less meaningful in high dimensions).

Interview Q&A

Q: Why does KNN require feature scaling, unlike decision trees? KNN relies on distance calculations between points. If one feature has a much larger numeric range than others (e.g. income in dollars vs. age in years), it will dominate the distance calculation regardless of its actual predictive importance. Decision trees split on individual feature thresholds one at a time, so the relative scale of different features doesn't affect how splits are chosen.

4.3 Support Vector Machines (SVM)

SVM finds the hyperplane that best separates classes by maximizing the **margin** — the distance between the hyperplane and the nearest data points of each class (called **support vectors**).

Key concepts: - **Hard margin SVM:** assumes perfectly separable data, no misclassification allowed. - **Soft margin SVM:** allows some misclassification, controlled by a regularization parameter C — small C allows more margin violations (more regularization, simpler boundary); large C fits training data more tightly (less regularization, risk of overfitting). - **Kernel trick:** transforms data into a higher-dimensional space to make it linearly separable, without explicitly computing the transformation (using kernel functions like RBF, polynomial). This lets SVM handle non-linear decision boundaries efficiently.

Interview Q&A

Q: Explain the kernel trick in SVM. Some datasets aren't linearly separable in their original

feature space, but might become separable if mapped into a higher-dimensional space. Explicitly transforming every point into this higher dimension can be computationally expensive. The kernel trick computes the dot product between points as if they were in that higher-dimensional space, without ever explicitly performing the transformation — using a kernel function (e.g. RBF: $K(x, y) = \exp(-\gamma ||x - y||^2)$). This makes non-linear classification computationally feasible.

4.4 Naive Bayes

Applies Bayes' theorem with a “naive” assumption that features are conditionally independent given the class:

$$P(\text{class} \mid \text{features}) \propto P(\text{class}) * \prod P(\text{feature}_i \mid \text{class})$$

Variants: - **Gaussian Naive Bayes:** assumes continuous features follow a normal distribution. - **Multinomial Naive Bayes:** commonly used for text classification (word counts/frequencies). - **Bernoulli Naive Bayes:** for binary/boolean features (word present/absent).

Laplace smoothing: prevents zero probabilities for feature values unseen during training, which would otherwise zero out the entire product regardless of other evidence:

$$P(\text{feature}=v \mid \text{class}) = (\text{count}(v, \text{class}) + 1) / (\text{count}(\text{class}) + \text{num_possible_values})$$

Interview Q&A

Q: Why does Naive Bayes work well in practice despite its unrealistic independence assumption? Even when the independence assumption doesn't strictly hold, Naive Bayes often still produces reasonably accurate class predictions because it only needs to rank classes correctly (which class has highest posterior probability), not estimate exact probabilities. The correlations between features often affect all classes similarly, so the *relative* ranking of posterior probabilities remains accurate even if the absolute probability values are biased.

Part 5: Decision Trees

5.1 How Decision Trees Work

A decision tree recursively splits the data into subsets based on feature values, forming a tree structure where each internal node represents a decision (a feature + threshold), each branch represents an outcome, and each leaf represents a final prediction.

Splitting Criteria

For classification: - **Gini Impurity:** $1 - \sum (p_i)^2$, where p_i is the proportion of class i in the node. Measures how often a randomly chosen element would be incorrectly classified. - **Entropy:** $-\sum p_i * \log_2(p_i)$. Measures disorder/uncertainty. Information Gain = entropy before split - weighted entropy after split.

For regression: - **Variance reduction:** choose the split that most reduces the variance of the target variable within child nodes.

```

def gini(y):
    classes = set(y)
    n = len(y)
    impurity = 1.0
    for c in classes:
        p = y.count(c) / n
        impurity -= p*p
    return impurity

def best_split(X, y):
    best_gini = float('inf')
    best_feature, best_threshold = None, None
    for feature in range(len(X[0])):
        thresholds = set(row[feature] for row in X)
        for t in thresholds:
            left_y = [y[i] for i in range(len(X)) if X[i][feature] <= t]
            right_y = [y[i] for i in range(len(X)) if X[i][feature] > t]
            if not left_y or not right_y:
                continue
            weighted_gini = (len(left_y)*gini(left_y) + len(right_y)*gini(right_y)) / len(y)
            if weighted_gini < best_gini:
                best_gini, best_feature, best_threshold = weighted_gini, feature, t
    return best_feature, best_threshold, best_gini

```

Stopping Criteria (to prevent overfitting)

- Maximum tree depth.
- Minimum samples required to split a node.
- Minimum samples required at a leaf node.
- Maximum number of leaf nodes.
- Minimum impurity decrease required to justify a split.

Pruning

- **Pre-pruning**: stop growing the tree early based on the stopping criteria above.
- **Post-pruning**: grow the full tree, then remove branches that provide little predictive power (e.g. cost-complexity pruning, which balances tree size against training error).

Interview Q&A

Q: What are the advantages and disadvantages of decision trees? **Advantages:** easy to interpret and visualize, handle both numerical and categorical data, require little data preprocessing (no need for scaling), can capture non-linear relationships and feature interactions naturally. **Disadvantages:** prone to overfitting (especially deep trees), unstable (small changes in data can produce a very different tree), biased toward features with more levels/split points, and greedy splitting doesn't guarantee a globally optimal tree.

Q: Gini impurity vs Entropy — does it matter which you use? In practice, they usually produce similar trees. Gini is slightly faster to compute (no logarithm) and is the default in many libraries (e.g. scikit-learn's CART implementation). Entropy is more sensitive to changes in class probabilities near the extremes. The choice rarely has a large practical impact on final model performance.

Part 6: Ensemble Methods

6.1 Why Ensembles Work

Combining multiple models often outperforms any single model, because different models make different errors — if those errors aren't perfectly correlated, averaging/voting cancels out some of the noise while reinforcing genuine signal. This is formalized by the **bias-variance decomposition**: ensembling primarily reduces variance (bagging) or bias (boosting), depending on the method.

6.2 Bagging (Bootstrap Aggregating)

Train multiple models independently on different **bootstrap samples** (random samples with replacement) of the training data, then combine their predictions (majority vote for classification, average for regression).

Random Forest = bagging applied to decision trees, with an added twist: at each split, only a random subset of features is considered (not all features), which decorrelates the trees further and improves the ensemble's variance reduction.

```
# Conceptual pseudocode for Random Forest prediction
def random_forest_predict(trees, x):
    predictions = [tree.predict(x) for tree in trees]
    return Counter(predictions).most_common(1)[0][0]
```

Key hyperparameters: number of trees, max depth per tree, number of features considered per split (`max_features`), min samples per leaf.

Interview Q&A

Q: Why does Random Forest randomly select a subset of features at each split, rather than just bagging the training samples? If all trees considered all features, they'd likely all pick similar strong features for their top splits, making the trees highly correlated — averaging correlated models doesn't reduce variance as effectively. By restricting each split to a random feature subset, individual trees are forced to sometimes use weaker/different features, decorrelating the trees and improving the ensemble's overall variance reduction.

6.3 Boosting

Train models **sequentially**, where each new model focuses on correcting the errors of the previous ensemble, typically by up-weighting misclassified examples (AdaBoost) or fitting to the residual errors (Gradient Boosting).

AdaBoost

1. Initialize equal weights for all training examples.
2. Train a weak learner (often a shallow decision tree, "stump").
3. Increase weights of misclassified examples, decrease weights of correctly classified ones.
4. Repeat, building a weighted ensemble of weak learners.
5. Final prediction: weighted vote of all learners, weighted by each learner's accuracy.

Gradient Boosting

1. Start with an initial prediction (e.g. the mean of y).

2. Compute residuals (errors) between actual and predicted values.
3. Train a new model to predict these residuals.
4. Add this new model's predictions (scaled by a learning rate) to the running total.
5. Repeat for a set number of iterations.

```
# Conceptual gradient boosting for regression
def gradient_boosting_predict(models, x, initial_pred, lr):
    pred = initial_pred
    for model in models:
        pred += lr * model.predict(x)
    return pred
```

Popular implementations: XGBoost, LightGBM, CatBoost — all add regularization, efficient handling of missing values, and speed optimizations on top of the core gradient boosting idea.

Interview Q&A

Q: Compare bagging and boosting. | Aspect | Bagging | Boosting | |—|—|—| | Training | Parallel, independent models | Sequential, each depends on previous | | Goal | Reduce variance | Reduce bias (and can reduce variance too) | | Base learners | Usually deep/complex (e.g. full trees) | Usually weak/shallow (e.g. stumps) | | Overfitting risk | Lower | Higher if not regularized (learning rate, depth, early stopping) | | Example | Random Forest | AdaBoost, XGBoost, LightGBM |

Q: What is the role of the learning rate in gradient boosting? It scales how much each new tree's prediction contributes to the overall ensemble. A smaller learning rate requires more trees to fit the data well but generally generalizes better (less overfitting per step); a larger learning rate converges faster but risks overshooting and overfitting. It's typically tuned jointly with the number of estimators.

6.4 Stacking

Train multiple different base models (e.g. logistic regression, random forest, SVM), then train a **meta-model** on their outputs (predictions) to learn how to best combine them. Unlike bagging/boosting, stacking can combine fundamentally different algorithm types, leveraging their different strengths.

Part 7: Clustering

7.1 K-Means Clustering

Partitions data into **k** clusters by iteratively assigning points to the nearest centroid and recomputing centroids as the mean of assigned points, until convergence (centroids stop moving significantly).

Algorithm: 1. Randomly initialize **k** centroids (or use k-means++ for smarter initialization). 2. Assign each point to its nearest centroid (by Euclidean distance). 3. Recompute each centroid as the mean of points assigned to it. 4. Repeat steps 2-3 until centroids stabilize or max iterations reached.

```
import random

def euclidean(a, b):
    return sum((a[i]-b[i])**2 for i in range(len(a))) ** 0.5

def kmeans(X, k, iterations=100, seed=1):
    random.seed(seed)
    centroids = random.sample(X, k)
    for _ in range(iterations):
        clusters = [[] for _ in range(k)]
        for point in X:
            dists = [euclidean(point, c) for c in centroids]
            clusters[dists.index(min(dists))].append(point)
        new_centroids = []
        for cluster in clusters:
            if cluster:
                dim = len(cluster[0])
                new_centroids.append([sum(p[d] for p in cluster)/len(cluster) for d in range(dim)])
            else:
                new_centroids.append(random.choice(X))
        if new_centroids == centroids:
            break
        centroids = new_centroids
    return centroids, clusters
```

Choosing k — Elbow Method: plot within-cluster sum of squares (WCSS/inertia) against different values of `k`; look for the “elbow” point where adding more clusters yields diminishing returns.

Choosing k — Silhouette Score: measures how similar a point is to its own cluster compared to other clusters, ranging from -1 to 1 (higher is better). Can be computed for various `k` and the best value chosen directly, unlike the more subjective elbow method.

Limitations: must specify `k` in advance, assumes roughly spherical/similarly-sized clusters, sensitive to initialization (mitigated by k-means++) and outliers, struggles with non-convex cluster shapes.

7.2 Hierarchical Clustering

Builds a tree (dendrogram) of clusters, either: - **Agglomerative (bottom-up):** start with each point as its own cluster, repeatedly merge the closest pair of clusters until one cluster remains. - **Divisive (top-down):** start with all points in one cluster, repeatedly split until each point is its own cluster.

Linkage methods (how “distance between clusters” is defined): - **Single linkage:** minimum distance between any two points in the two clusters. - **Complete linkage:** maximum distance between any two points. - **Average linkage:** average distance between all pairs of points. - **Ward’s method:** minimizes the increase in total within-cluster variance after merging.

Advantage over K-Means: no need to specify `k` in advance — you can “cut” the dendrogram at any level to get the desired number of clusters, and the dendrogram itself gives insight into the data’s nested structure.

7.3 DBSCAN (Density-Based Clustering)

Groups together points that are closely packed, marking points in low-density regions as outliers/noise.

Key parameters: - `eps` : maximum distance between two points to be considered neighbors. - `min_samples` : minimum number of points required to form a dense region (a “core point”).

Point types: **Core point** (has at least `min_samples` neighbors within `eps`), **Border point** (within `eps` of a core point but doesn't have enough neighbors itself), **Noise point** (neither — treated as an outlier, not assigned to any cluster).

Advantages over K-Means: doesn't require specifying the number of clusters, can find arbitrarily shaped clusters (not just spherical), naturally identifies outliers rather than forcing every point into a cluster.

Interview Q&A

Q: When would you choose DBSCAN over K-Means? When clusters have irregular shapes (not spherical), when the number of clusters is unknown, or when you expect outliers/noise in the data that shouldn't be forced into any cluster. K-Means is preferable when clusters are roughly spherical/similar-sized and you have a good estimate of `k`, since it's generally faster and simpler to tune.

Q: How do you choose `eps` and `min_samples` for DBSCAN? `min_samples` is often set based on domain knowledge or as a rule of thumb (e.g. $2 \times \text{number of dimensions}$). `eps` is commonly chosen using a **k-distance graph**: plot the distance to the k-th nearest neighbor for every point, sorted in ascending order, and look for the “knee” in the curve — that distance is a reasonable `eps`.

Part 8: Dimensionality Reduction

8.1 Why Reduce Dimensionality?

High-dimensional data suffers from the **curse of dimensionality**: distances between points become less meaningful, models need exponentially more data to generalize, computation becomes expensive, and visualization becomes impossible beyond 3 dimensions. Dimensionality reduction compresses features while preserving as much important information/structure as possible.

Benefits: faster training, reduced overfitting risk (fewer parameters to learn), noise reduction, enables visualization, can reveal underlying structure in the data.

8.2 Principal Component Analysis (PCA)

PCA finds new axes (principal components) that capture the maximum variance in the data, ordered by how much variance each explains. It's a **linear** technique.

Steps: 1. Standardize the data (mean 0, unit variance) — PCA is sensitive to scale. 2. Compute the covariance matrix of the features. 3. Compute eigenvectors and eigenvalues of the covariance matrix. 4. Sort eigenvectors by their corresponding eigenvalues (descending) — these are the principal components, ranked by how much variance they explain. 5. Select the top `k` components and project the data onto them.

```
import numpy as np

def pca(X, n_components):
    X_meaned = X - np.mean(X, axis=0)
    cov_matrix = np.cov(X_meaned, rowvar=False)
    eigenvalues, eigenvectors = np.linalg.eigh(cov_matrix)
    sorted_idx = np.argsort(eigenvalues)[::-1]
    eigenvectors_sorted = eigenvectors[:, sorted_idx]
    top_components = eigenvectors_sorted[:, :n_components]
    return X_meaned @ top_components
```

Explained variance ratio: tells you what fraction of total variance each principal component captures — used to decide how many components to keep (e.g. keep enough components to explain 95% of total variance).

Interview Q&A

Q: Why must you standardize data before PCA? PCA identifies directions of maximum variance. If features are on different scales (e.g. income in thousands vs. age in tens), the feature with the larger numeric range will dominate the variance calculation regardless of its actual importance, skewing the principal components toward that feature rather than reflecting genuine underlying structure.

Q: Is PCA a feature selection or feature extraction technique? Feature **extraction** — it creates new features (principal components) that are linear combinations of the original features, rather than selecting a subset of the original features unchanged. This means the resulting components often lose direct interpretability compared to the original features.

8.3 t-SNE (t-Distributed Stochastic Neighbor Embedding)

A **non-linear** dimensionality reduction technique primarily used for visualization (typically reducing to 2 or 3 dimensions). It preserves local structure — points that are close together in high-dimensional space remain close in the low-dimensional embedding — by modeling pairwise similarities as probabilities and minimizing the divergence between high-dimensional and low-dimensional similarity distributions.

Key hyperparameter — perplexity: roughly controls the balance between preserving local vs. global structure; typical values range from 5-50.

Caveats: t-SNE is primarily for visualization, not general-purpose preprocessing before another model (unlike PCA) — it's computationally expensive, non-deterministic (different runs can look different), and the distances *between* clusters in a t-SNE plot aren't necessarily meaningful (only relative closeness within local neighborhoods is reliable).

8.4 Autoencoders

A neural network trained to reconstruct its input, with a “bottleneck” hidden layer of smaller dimensionality than the input. The bottleneck layer's activations serve as a compressed, non-linear representation of the input — a form of learned, non-linear dimensionality reduction, in contrast to PCA's linear approach.

Interview Q&A

Q: PCA vs t-SNE vs Autoencoders — when would you use each? **PCA:** fast, linear,

interpretable, good for general preprocessing/compression before another model, and when relationships in data are roughly linear. **t-SNE**: best for visualizing high-dimensional data in 2D/3D to explore cluster structure, not for feeding into downstream models. **Autoencoders**: best when relationships are non-linear and you have enough data to train a neural network, and you want a reusable, non-linear compression function (unlike t-SNE, an autoencoder's encoder can be applied to new data without retraining).

Part 9: Feature Engineering

9.1 Why Feature Engineering Matters

Even the most powerful algorithm can't learn signal that isn't represented in the input features. Well-engineered features often improve model performance more than switching to a fancier algorithm — it's frequently cited as the highest-leverage activity in a typical ML project.

9.2 Common Techniques

Handling missing values: - Drop rows/columns (if missingness is small and random). - Impute with mean/median (numerical) or mode (categorical). - Model-based imputation (KNN imputer, regression imputation). - Add a binary "is_missing" indicator column, which can itself carry signal (e.g. missingness might correlate with the target).

Encoding categorical variables: - **One-hot encoding**: for low-cardinality nominal features. - **Ordinal encoding**: for ordered categories. - **Target encoding**: replace category with the mean target value for that category — useful for high-cardinality features, but risks leakage/overfitting if not done carefully (e.g. using cross-validation folds to compute encodings). - **Frequency encoding**: replace category with its frequency count.

Scaling numerical features: - **Min-Max scaling**: rescales to a fixed range, typically [0,1]. - **Standardization (z-score)**: centers to mean 0, std 1. - **Robust scaling**: uses median and IQR instead of mean/std — less sensitive to outliers.

Creating new features: - Interaction terms (e.g. `price_per_sqft = price / sqft`). - Polynomial features (e.g. `x2`, `x*y`). - Date/time decomposition (day of week, month, is_weekend, time since event). - Aggregations (e.g. average purchase amount per customer, over a rolling window). - Text features (TF-IDF, word counts, embeddings). - Binning continuous variables into categories (e.g. age groups).

```
def min_max_scale(X):
    n_features = len(X[0])
    mins = [min(row[j] for row in X) for j in range(n_features)]
    maxs = [max(row[j] for row in X) for j in range(n_features)]
    return [[(row[j]-mins[j])/(maxs[j]-mins[j]) if maxs[j] != mins[j] else 0
              for j in range(n_features)] for row in X]
```

9.3 Feature Selection

Reducing the number of features used, to simplify the model, reduce overfitting, and improve

interpretability/speed.

- **Filter methods:** select features based on statistical measures independent of the model (e.g. correlation with target, chi-squared test, mutual information).
- **Wrapper methods:** use the model's performance to evaluate feature subsets (e.g. Recursive Feature Elimination — iteratively remove the least important feature and re-evaluate).
- **Embedded methods:** feature selection happens as part of model training (e.g. Lasso's coefficient shrinkage to zero, tree-based feature importances).

Interview Q&A

Q: What's the danger of target encoding, and how do you mitigate it? If you compute the target encoding using the entire training set (including the row being encoded), you leak information about that row's own target value into its feature — causing severe overfitting and unrealistically good training performance that won't hold on test data. Mitigation: compute encodings using cross-validation (encode each fold using statistics from the *other* folds only), or add smoothing/regularization toward the global mean for low-frequency categories.

Q: How do you handle high-cardinality categorical features (e.g. thousands of unique zip codes)? One-hot encoding would create thousands of sparse columns — inefficient and prone to overfitting. Better options: target encoding (with proper leakage prevention), frequency encoding, grouping rare categories into an "other" bucket, hashing tricks, or using embedding layers if working with a neural network.

Part 10: Overfitting & Underfitting

10.1 Definitions

Underfitting: the model is too simple to capture the underlying pattern in the data — poor performance on both training and test data. Caused by insufficient model complexity, too much regularization, or too few relevant features.

Overfitting: the model learns the training data too well, including its noise and random fluctuations — great performance on training data but poor generalization to unseen data. Caused by excessive model complexity relative to the amount/quality of training data, insufficient regularization, or training for too long (in iterative methods).

Good fit: the model captures the true underlying pattern without memorizing noise — good performance on both training and unseen data.

10.2 Diagnosing Overfitting/Underfitting

Plot training error and validation error as a function of model complexity (or training epochs): -

- **Underfitting:** both training and validation error are high, and close to each other. - **Overfitting:** training error is low, but validation error is high — a large gap between the two. - **Good fit:** both errors are low and relatively close together.

Learning curves (error vs. training set size) are another diagnostic tool: if both curves plateau at a high error with a small gap, the model is underfitting (more data won't help much — need more complexity). If there's a persistent large gap between training and validation error even as data

grows, the model is overfitting (more data may help, or reduce complexity/add regularization).

10.3 Fixing Overfitting

- Get more training data.
- Simplify the model (fewer features, shallower trees, fewer parameters).
- Add regularization (L1/L2, dropout).
- Use cross-validation to tune hyperparameters robustly.
- Early stopping (stop training when validation error starts increasing).
- Data augmentation (especially in image/text tasks).
- Ensemble methods (e.g. bagging reduces variance).
- Feature selection — remove noisy/irrelevant features.

10.4 Fixing Underfitting

- Increase model complexity (more features, deeper trees, more parameters/layers).
- Reduce regularization strength.
- Train for longer / more iterations.
- Add more relevant features (better feature engineering).
- Try a more powerful algorithm.

Interview Q&A

Q: You have a model with 99% training accuracy but 65% test accuracy. What's happening, and what do you do? This is a classic overfitting signature — the model has memorized the training data (including noise) rather than learning generalizable patterns. Steps: check for data leakage first (sometimes a huge gap is actually a bug, not true overfitting). If genuinely overfitting: reduce model complexity, add regularization, gather more data, use cross-validation, and consider ensemble methods like bagging.

Q: Can a model be both overfitting and underfitting at the same time? Not in the classic sense for a single global measure, but it's possible for a model to underfit certain regions of the feature space while overfitting others — e.g. a decision tree might have very deep, overfit branches in dense data regions while having very shallow, underfit branches in sparse regions. This is one reason ensemble methods and careful per-region validation can be valuable.

Part 11: Bias-Variance Tradeoff

11.1 Decomposing Prediction Error

For a given model, the expected prediction error at a point can be decomposed into three components:

$$\text{Total Error} = \text{Bias}^2 + \text{Variance} + \text{Irreducible Error}$$

- **Bias**: error from incorrect assumptions in the model (e.g. assuming a linear relationship when the true relationship is non-linear). High bias → underfitting.

- **Variance**: error from the model's sensitivity to small fluctuations in the training set. High variance → overfitting (the model changes drastically if trained on a slightly different sample).
- **Irreducible Error**: noise inherent in the data itself, which no model can eliminate (e.g. measurement error, unmeasured variables).

11.2 The Tradeoff

As model complexity increases: - Bias tends to **decrease** (the model can capture more complex patterns). - Variance tends to **increase** (the model becomes more sensitive to the specific training sample).

The goal is to find the complexity level that minimizes the **sum** of bias² and variance — not to eliminate either individually, since a zero-bias model (perfectly memorizing training data) typically has very high variance, and vice versa.

11.3 Bias-Variance by Algorithm

Algorithm	Typical bias/variance profile
Linear Regression	High bias, low variance (simple, stable)
Deep Decision Tree	Low bias, high variance (flexible, unstable)
KNN (small k)	Low bias, high variance
KNN (large k)	Higher bias, lower variance
Random Forest	Lower variance than single tree (via averaging)
Regularized models (Ridge/Lasso)	Slightly higher bias, lower variance than unregularized

Interview Q&A

Q: How does increasing k in KNN affect bias and variance? Increasing k averages over more neighbors, smoothing the decision boundary — this **increases bias** (the model becomes less sensitive to local patterns, more likely to miss fine-grained structure) but **decreases variance** (less sensitive to noise from any single nearby point). Decreasing k does the opposite.

Q: How does regularization affect the bias-variance tradeoff? Regularization (L1/L2) constrains model complexity, which typically **increases bias slightly** (the model is less free to fit the training data exactly) but **decreases variance substantially** (the model is less sensitive to the specific training sample) — usually a favorable tradeoff when the unregularized model was overfitting.

Part 12: Evaluation Metrics

12.1 Classification Metrics

Confusion Matrix: a table showing True Positives (TP), True Negatives (TN), False Positives (FP), and False Negatives (FN).

	Predicted Positive	Predicted Negative
Actual Positive	TP	FN
Actual Negative	FP	TN

- **Accuracy** = $(TP+TN) / (TP+TN+FP+FN)$ — overall correctness. Misleading on imbalanced data.
- **Precision** = $TP / (TP+FP)$ — of predicted positives, how many were correct.
- **Recall (Sensitivity)** = $TP / (TP+FN)$ — of actual positives, how many were caught.
- **Specificity** = $TN / (TN+FP)$ — of actual negatives, how many were correctly identified.
- **F1-Score** = $2 \times (Precision \times Recall) / (Precision + Recall)$ — harmonic mean, balances precision and recall.
- **F-beta score**: weighted version of F1, where $\beta > 1$ weights recall more heavily, $\beta < 1$ weights precision more heavily.

```
def precision_recall_f1(y_true, y_pred, positive_label=1):
    tp = sum(1 for t, p in zip(y_true, y_pred) if t == positive_label and p == positive_label)
    fp = sum(1 for t, p in zip(y_true, y_pred) if t != positive_label and p == positive_label)
    fn = sum(1 for t, p in zip(y_true, y_pred) if t == positive_label and p != positive_label)
    precision = tp / (tp + fp) if (tp+fp) > 0 else 0
    recall = tp / (tp + fn) if (tp+fn) > 0 else 0
    f1 = 2*precision*recall / (precision+recall) if (precision+recall) > 0 else 0
    return precision, recall, f1
```

ROC Curve & AUC: ROC plots True Positive Rate (Recall) vs. False Positive Rate across all classification thresholds. AUC (Area Under the Curve) summarizes performance across all thresholds — 1.0 is perfect, 0.5 is random guessing. Threshold-independent, good for comparing models.

Precision-Recall Curve: plots precision vs. recall across thresholds — more informative than ROC-AUC for highly imbalanced datasets, since it focuses specifically on the positive (minority) class's performance.

Log Loss (Cross-Entropy): penalizes confident wrong predictions heavily — rewards well-calibrated probability estimates, not just correct class labels.

12.2 Regression Metrics

- **MAE** (Mean Absolute Error): average of absolute differences — robust to outliers.
- **MSE** (Mean Squared Error): average of squared differences — penalizes large errors more.
- **RMSE** (Root MSE): same units as the target variable, still penalizes large errors.
- **R²**: proportion of variance in the target explained by the model (1 = perfect, 0 = no better than predicting the mean).
- **Adjusted R²**: penalizes R² for adding features that don't meaningfully improve fit.
- **MAPE** (Mean Absolute Percentage Error): average absolute percentage difference — interpretable, but undefined/unstable when actual values are near zero.

12.3 Ranking & Recommendation Metrics

- **Precision@K / Recall@K**: precision/recall considering only the top K recommended/ranked

items.

- **Mean Average Precision (MAP)**: averages precision at each relevant item's rank position, then averages across queries.
- **NDCG (Normalized Discounted Cumulative Gain)**: accounts for the position of relevant items in a ranked list, giving more credit to relevant items ranked higher.

Interview Q&A

Q: Your classifier has 95% accuracy on a dataset where only 5% of samples are positive. Is this a good model? Not necessarily — a trivial model that always predicts “negative” would also achieve 95% accuracy while being completely useless for identifying positives. You need to look at precision, recall, F1, or the confusion matrix directly to understand whether the model is actually finding positive cases, not just matching the class imbalance in the data.

Q: When would you use ROC-AUC vs. Precision-Recall AUC? Use ROC-AUC when classes are roughly balanced, or when both false positives and false negatives matter comparably. Use Precision-Recall AUC when dealing with heavily imbalanced data and you care primarily about performance on the minority (positive) class — ROC-AUC can look misleadingly good on imbalanced data since the True Negative count (which dominates the denominator of the false positive rate) is large, making the false positive rate look artificially small even when precision is poor.

Part 13: Cross-Validation

13.1 Why Cross-Validation?

A single train/test split gives one estimate of model performance, which can be noisy — especially with smaller datasets, the specific split chosen can significantly affect the measured performance, potentially misleading model selection or hyperparameter tuning decisions. Cross-validation provides a more robust performance estimate by testing across multiple different splits.

13.2 K-Fold Cross-Validation

1. Split the data into k equally-sized folds.
2. For each fold i : train on the remaining $k-1$ folds, validate on fold i .
3. Average the performance metric across all k runs.

Common choice: $k=5$ or $k=10$. Larger k gives a more reliable estimate but is more computationally expensive (and each training set is more similar to the full dataset, which can slightly bias the estimate optimistically for very large k , e.g. Leave-One-Out CV).

```
def k_fold_indices(n, k):
    fold_size = n // k
    indices = list(range(n))
    folds = [indices[i*fold_size:(i+1)*fold_size] for i in range(k)]
    return folds

def cross_validate(X, y, model_fn, k=5):
    folds = k_fold_indices(len(X), k)
    scores = []
```

```

for i in range(k):
    test_idx = set(folds[i])
    train_idx = [j for j in range(len(X)) if j not in test_idx]
    X_train = [X[j] for j in train_idx]; y_train = [y[j] for j in train_idx]
    X_test = [X[j] for j in folds[i]]; y_test = [y[j] for j in folds[i]]
    model = model_fn(X_train, y_train)
    score = model.evaluate(X_test, y_test)
    scores.append(score)
return sum(scores) / len(scores)

```

13.3 Variants

- **Stratified K-Fold**: preserves the class distribution in each fold — important for imbalanced classification, to ensure every fold has a representative mix of classes.
- **Leave-One-Out CV (LOOCV)**: each fold contains exactly one sample — very thorough but computationally expensive for large datasets, and can have high variance in its estimate.
- **Time Series Cross-Validation**: for temporal data, folds must respect chronological order (never train on future data to predict the past) — typically implemented as a rolling or expanding window.
- **Group K-Fold**: ensures samples from the same group (e.g. same patient, same user) never appear in both train and test folds simultaneously, preventing leakage through correlated samples.

Interview Q&A

Q: Why is random K-Fold cross-validation inappropriate for time series data? Randomly shuffling time series data into folds can result in training on data that comes *after* the validation period chronologically — effectively letting the model “see the future” during training, producing an overly optimistic performance estimate that won’t hold in real deployment (where you only ever have past data to predict the future). Time series CV must preserve chronological order.

Q: How does cross-validation help with hyperparameter tuning specifically? Instead of tuning hyperparameters based on performance on a single validation set (which risks overfitting to that particular split), cross-validation evaluates each hyperparameter combination across multiple folds and averages the results, giving a more reliable signal of which hyperparameters generalize well — reducing the risk of picking hyperparameters that happen to work well on one lucky split but poorly elsewhere.

Part 14: Optimization

14.1 Gradient Descent Fundamentals

Gradient descent is an iterative optimization algorithm that adjusts model parameters in the direction that reduces the loss function, using the gradient (partial derivatives) of the loss with respect to each parameter:

```

w_new = w_old - learning_rate * gradient(loss, w_old)

```

Learning rate controls the step size. Too small → slow convergence. Too large → overshooting, divergence, or oscillation around the minimum.

14.2 Variants of Gradient Descent

- **Batch Gradient Descent**: computes the gradient using the *entire* training set per update. Accurate gradient estimate, but slow and memory-heavy for large datasets.
- **Stochastic Gradient Descent (SGD)**: updates parameters using *one* training example at a time. Fast, but noisy updates (high variance in the gradient estimate).
- **Mini-Batch Gradient Descent**: updates using a small batch (e.g. 32–256 examples). A practical middle ground — standard in modern deep learning, balances speed and stability, and benefits from vectorized hardware (GPU) operations.

14.3 Advanced Optimizers

- **Momentum**: accumulates a moving average of past gradients to smooth out updates and accelerate convergence in consistent directions, while dampening oscillations.
- **AdaGrad**: adapts the learning rate per parameter based on the historical sum of squared gradients — parameters with large/frequent gradients get smaller effective learning rates. Can cause the learning rate to shrink too aggressively over time.
- **RMSProp**: similar to AdaGrad but uses an exponentially decaying average of past squared gradients, preventing the learning rate from shrinking to near-zero over long training runs.
- **Adam (Adaptive Moment Estimation)**: combines momentum and RMSProp — tracks both the first moment (mean) and second moment (variance) of gradients. Widely used as a strong default optimizer in deep learning due to its robustness across a wide range of problems.

```
# Simplified momentum update
def momentum_update(w, grad, velocity, lr=0.01, beta=0.9):
    velocity = beta * velocity + (1 - beta) * grad
    w = w - lr * velocity
    return w, velocity
```

14.4 Learning Rate Scheduling

Adjusting the learning rate over the course of training, rather than keeping it fixed: - **Step decay**: reduce the learning rate by a factor every fixed number of epochs. - **Exponential decay**: continuously decay the learning rate exponentially over time. - **Cosine annealing**: smoothly decreases the learning rate following a cosine curve, sometimes with periodic “restarts.” - **Warm-up**: start with a small learning rate and gradually increase it for the first few steps/epochs, before applying the main schedule — helps stabilize early training, especially for large models.

14.5 Convexity & Local Minima

A **convex** loss function (e.g. linear regression’s MSE, logistic regression’s cross-entropy) has a single global minimum — gradient descent is guaranteed to converge to it (given an appropriate learning rate). **Non-convex** loss functions (e.g. most deep neural network losses) can have multiple local minima and saddle points. In practice, for deep networks, many local minima tend to have similar (good) loss values, and techniques like momentum and stochastic noise (from mini-batches) help escape shallow local minima and saddle points.

Interview Q&A

Q: Why is Adam often preferred as a default optimizer over plain SGD? Adam adapts the learning rate per parameter and incorporates momentum, making it more robust to poor learning rate choices and less sensitive to the scale of gradients across different parameters — this often leads to faster, more stable convergence with less manual tuning, especially early in a project. However, well-tuned SGD (with momentum and a good learning rate schedule) can sometimes generalize slightly better in the final model for certain tasks (a known empirical observation in some deep learning research), so it's not a universal rule.

Q: What's the difference between a local minimum and a saddle point, and why does this matter in high-dimensional optimization? A local minimum is a point where the loss is locally lowest in every direction. A saddle point is a point where the loss is a minimum in some directions but a maximum in others — the gradient is zero, but it's not actually a good stopping point. In very high-dimensional spaces (like deep neural networks), saddle points are far more common than true local minima, since it becomes exponentially less likely that *all* directions simultaneously curve upward at a random critical point. This is one reason optimizers that add noise or momentum (helping “push through” flat/saddle regions) are valuable in deep learning.

Appendix A: Full Quick-Reference Cheat Sheet

Topic	Key takeaway
Bias-Variance	More complexity → lower bias, higher variance
L1 vs L2	L1 → sparsity/feature selection; L2 → smooth shrinkage
Precision vs Recall	Precision: false positives costly; Recall: false negatives costly
Bagging vs Boosting	Bagging reduces variance (parallel); Boosting reduces bias (sequential)
Normalization vs Standardization	Normalization: bounded range; Standardization: mean 0, std 1
K-Means vs DBSCAN	K-Means: spherical, need k; DBSCAN: arbitrary shape, finds outliers
PCA vs t-SNE	PCA: linear, general preprocessing; t-SNE: non-linear, visualization only
Overfitting fix	More data, regularization, simpler model, cross-validation
Underfitting fix	More complexity, less regularization, better features
Cross-validation	More robust performance estimate than a single split
Adam optimizer	Combines momentum + adaptive per-parameter learning rates

Appendix B: Common End-to-End Interview Questions

Q: Walk me through how you would approach a new ML problem from scratch. 1. Clarify the business problem and success metric. 2. Understand and explore the data (EDA) — distributions, missing values, correlations, target balance. 3. Split data into train/validation/test *before* any preprocessing that uses statistics from the data (to avoid leakage). 4. Clean and preprocess: handle missing values, encode categoricals, scale numerals. 5. Engineer features based on domain knowledge and EDA insights. 6. Start with a simple baseline model to establish a performance floor. 7. Iterate with more sophisticated models, using cross-validation for robust comparison. 8. Tune hyperparameters (grid search, random search, or Bayesian optimization). 9. Evaluate on the held-out test set only once, at the end, to get an unbiased final estimate. 10. Consider interpretability, fairness, and edge cases before deployment. 11. Deploy, monitor performance over time, and set up retraining pipelines as data drifts.

Q: How do you decide which model to use for a given problem? Consider: the type of task (regression/classification/clustering), size and dimensionality of the data, whether interpretability is required (e.g. regulated industries often need explainable models), training/inference time constraints, and whether relationships in the data are likely linear or non-linear. It's common practice to start with a simple, interpretable baseline (e.g. logistic/linear regression) and only move to more complex models (ensembles, neural networks) if the added complexity yields a meaningful performance improvement that justifies the tradeoff in interpretability and maintenance cost.

Q: What is data leakage, and how do you prevent it? Data leakage occurs when information from outside the training dataset (often inadvertently including information from the test/validation set, or future information not available at prediction time) is used to train the model, leading to overly optimistic performance estimates that don't hold in production. Prevention: always split data into train/test *before* any preprocessing/feature engineering step that computes statistics from the data (scaling, imputation, target encoding); ensure no future information leaks into features for time-based problems; be careful with grouped data (e.g. same user in both train and test) using group-aware splitting.